TABULA RASA
PETERSON KAMWATHI

25.04.2026 - 23.08.2026

NAIROBI CONTEMPORARY ART INSTITUTE

Tabula Rasa is Peterson Kamwathi's first major institutional solo exhibition — and his first such exhibition in Nairobi. The works, made between 2022 and 2026, span drawing, printmaking, sculpture, video, and a site-specific wall drawing. Across these forms, drawing remains the unifying discipline: not a preparatory step toward something else, but a sustained mode of thinking. It is the practice through which Kamwathi looks, and looking, for him, is never passive.

Tabula Rasa — the blank slate — is the philosophical idea that we enter the world without prior knowledge, open and unmarked. To declare something a blank slate, however, is itself a choice: a decision about what counts as visible, whose history is recognised, and who holds the authority to make such distinctions. Erasure is not the absence of history; it is an act within the construction of history.

Through a practice that looks at and uses images as fragments of larger narratives, Kamwathi assembles figures, monuments, maps, and ordinary objects from multiple places and moments, treating each as a bearer of unstable meaning. His surfaces layer drawing with printmaking techniques such as silkscreening and stencilling, and various wet and dry media, producing compositions that invite attention to seemingly banal objects and encounters — bringing them into proximity in ways that surface the charged histories they carry. Across these works, images shift between transparency and opacity, clarity and obfuscation. The reproducibility of printmaking sits alongside the close, searching attention of drawing. Equally, the stories embedded in the works hold in tension what is distributed and repeated against what is singular and specific. These are not only visual qualities — they are arguments about what dominant narratives of history make visible, and what they choose to bury..

The sculptures extend this drawing practice beyond the surface and into three-dimensional space: line drawings rendered in steel, monumental in scale, while retaining the quality of a mark made by hand. The animation, developed from Kamwathi's drawings and embedded within the large wall drawing that extends across all three exhibition spaces, gives that mark duration. The wall drawing itself depicts a series of interconnected encounters — between individuals and groups, between people and space, between people and monuments — and sits in dialogue with the other works throughout.

Across all the forms in the exhibition, what is elevated — what is, in a sense, monumentalised — is the everyday: ordinary gestures and unremarkable actions that sweeping historical accounts tend to overlook. This is Kamwathi's consistent counter-proposal to the logic of the monument: that meaning accumulates not only in grand events and consecrated figures, but in what is quiet, collective, and easily passed over. To move through the exhibition is to experience that argument spatially — across rooms, across scales, across the persistent presence of the drawn mark.

The works in this exhibition propose that our shared histories — political and personal — are not settled. They remain open, contested, still subject to other ways of telling. Kamwathi offers something more valuable than resolution: a set of images precise enough to slow us down, and open enough to let us look again

Tabula Rasa is curated by Don Handa

Gallery 1



1. *Vantage*, 2026
   Graphite, colour pencil, soft pastel, silkscreen, spray paint on 300gsm Canson watercolour paper

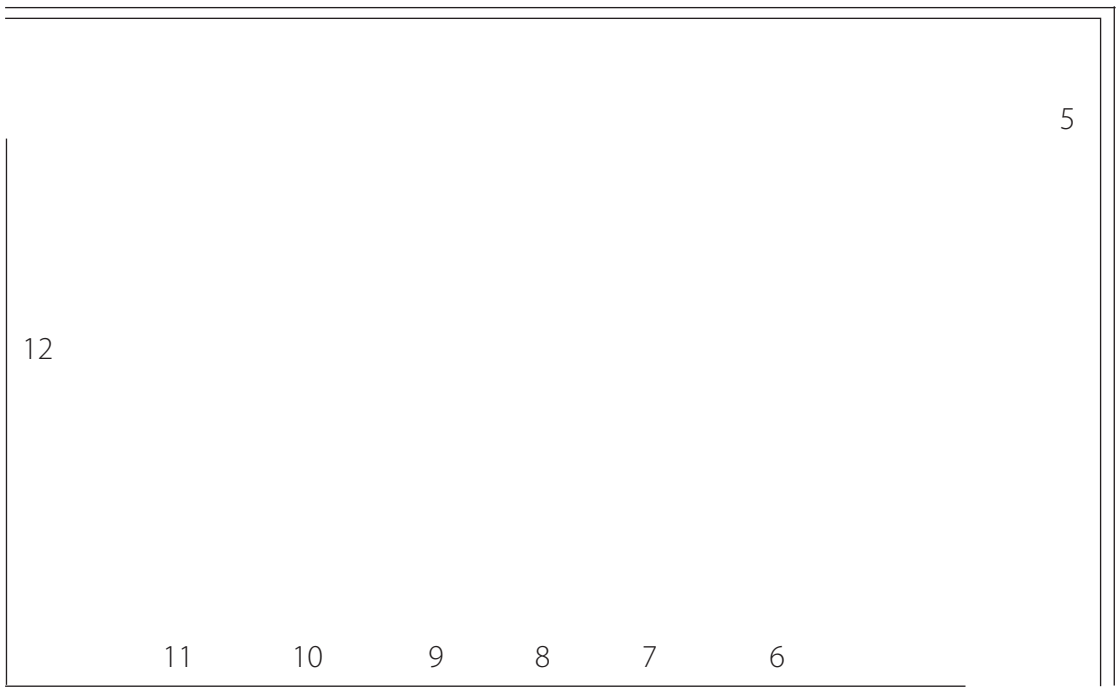
2. *Untitled*, 2025-26
   Soft pastel, pencil, graphite pencil and colour pencil on 300gsm Canson watercolour paper

3. *Reframing IV*, 2026
   Etching, aquatint on paper

4. *Untitled*, 2026
   Mild steel

5. *Tabula Rasa*, 2026
   Soft pastel, spray paint wall drawing

Gallery 2



5. *Tabula Rasa*, 2026
Soft pastel, spray paint wall drawing

6. *Untitled*, 2023-24
Graphite pencil, colour pencil, soft pastel, spray paint on 300gsm arches aquarelle paper.

7. *Debris II*, 2024-26
Graphite, colour pencil, soft pastel, spray paint and charcoal on 300gsm canson watercolour paper

8. *Flavour ya Strawberry,* 2023-24
Graphite pencil, colour pencil, soft pastel, and silkscreen on 300gsm canson watercolour paper

9. *Uneasy Lies the Head,* 2023-24
Graphite, colour pencil, soft pastel, spray paint, silkscreen on 300gsm canson watercolour paper

10. *Objects: Nyumbani*, 2023-24
Charcoal, graphite pencil, soft pastel, spray paint 300gsm arches aquarelle watercolor paper

11. *Objects: Monuments*, 2023-25
Graphite, colour pencil, soft pastel, silkscreen, spray paint on 300gsm arches aquarelle paper

12. *Consta(Nations)*, 2023-25
Charcoal, graphite pencil, color pencil, soft pastel, silkscreen, woodcut, spray paint on 300gsm arches aquarelle paper

Flavour Ya Strawberry (2023–24)
A child hangs at the composition's centre, both arms stretched upward gripping an unseen bar, legs dangling and bent at the knee — the posture of a child on monkey bars, effortful and playful at once. The picture plane is divided by sharp diagonal lines into distinct zones that bleed into one another, creating an almost hexagonal opening around the child, as though the composition itself frames this suspended figure within a fractured world.

In the upper left area of the drawing, a vivid pink soldier stands amid tumbling bodies. The upper right section features a flock of birds in flight, and directly below them is a column of figures, most of them dressed in plain robes and seen from behind. Further down we find a group of uniformed soldiers, and on the opposite side, another group of undifferentiated figures. Across all these zones, Kamwathi deliberately withholds individual distinction — no face, no singular quality separates one figure from the next. This is a recurring concern in Kamwathi's practice: collective identity, whether of protest, institution, or faith, is built on what is held in common, which necessarily means setting aside what makes each person singular. To be legible as part of a group is always also a kind of incompleteness.

Against these surroundings, the child rendered with full particularity, alone in full colour — holds on, mid-play, inside a world in motion. The title references the 2024 Kenyan Gen Z protests, when a protester

inhaled from a teargas canister and quipped that police should bring strawberry-flavoured gas next time. Humour, defiance, play, persisting inside violence.

Uneasy Lies the Head (2023–24)
A saddled but riderless horse — headless, its neck terminating abruptly at the upper edge of its body — occupies the centre of the composition. This horse stands on a plinth dense with text: commodity numbers/code that function as both pedestal and archive. The horse's saddle is packed and ready, yet neither rider nor head appears. This absence is characteristic of Kamwathi's broader practice, in which he has adopted various strategies of eliminating individual identity. In this case, and in several other instances in this body of work, he does so by eliminating the recognizable features of the head and face. It is a refusal to locate power, agency, suffering, sometimes tenderness, in a single identifiable figure, insisting instead on the structural and the collective. The horse faces away from the viewer, toward a scene it cannot be seen to witness.

Layered behind and around this central figure, through Kamwathi's characteristic use of transparent, ghosted imagery, are scenes suggestive of labour and coercion: a soldier advances from the left, weapon raised and at the upper right, figures push wheelbarrows across flattened terrain; underneath these, upside down in a lighter register still, figures mill about, appearing to be observing a central monumental figure. A red grid bisects the upper picture plane, suggestive of land survey, colonial mapping, or the administrative ordering of landscape. This is echoed below in a curved, geometric form drawn in orange — a faceted, crystalline fragment of a globe — that simultaneously frames, contains, and exposes. Below the surface, organic forms — roots, clouds, plant matter — press upward, outward, resisting burial.

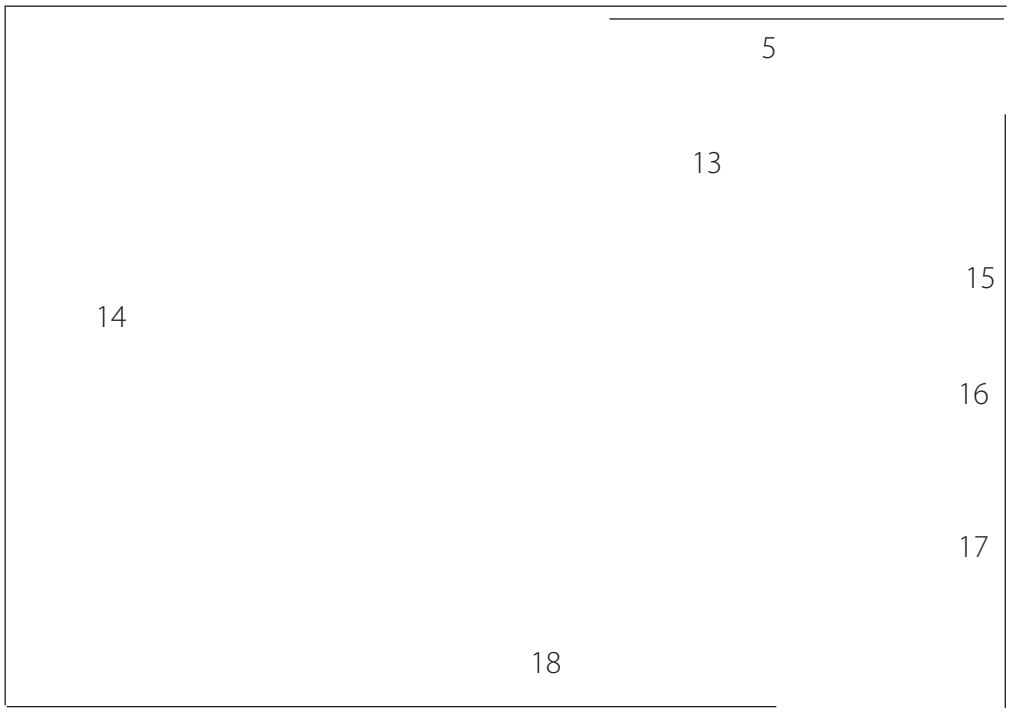
The head alluded to in the title — "uneasy lies the head that wears a crown" — is absent. No head, no crown; only the horse, the plinth, the cage. Power is present but evacuated of its figure, distributed across structures — geometric, archival, economic — that outlast any individual agent. Kamwathi's layering of media and imagery enacts this formally: the mechanical reproduction of the silkscreen, the close intimacy of drawing, the layering and diffusion of the soft pastels and spray paints, the deployment of, at-first-glace, disparate images and references. All these elements and gestures operate together, working singly and in concert, recording and obscuring—as involved and entangled with one another as are the systems and histories that inform their inclusion in this work.

Consta(Nations) (2023–25)
In *Consta(Nations)*, a figure rendered in graphite and charcoal sits with their back to the viewer, the back of their head visible, flowing garments gathered around them. Their posture is one of repose and contemplation — neither collapsed nor alert, but suspended in a state of deliberate, weighted attention. Around this figure, the picture plane is organised as a dense chromatic grid of discrete panels, each containing an image, symbol, or fragment: a cotton boll and what appears to be sisal — cash crops whose histories encode colonial agriculture, monoculture economies, and the extraction of land and labour across the Global South. A flea. A microscope. A segment of an arm marked with tally lines at the wrist. A schematic recognisable as a diagram for the arrangement of enslaved bodies in a ship's hold — one of modernity's most chilling administrative documents. Fragments of maps, barcodes, dense text, pixelated noise, and the visual static of a failed telecommunications signal recur across the panels.

This last reference is also the root of this work's formal logic. The multicoloured grid echoes the colour bars which, in analogue televisions, indicate an invalid video signal. For Kamwathi, the signal is everywhere, embedded in objects, bodies, histories, and data streams both analogue and digital. Ours is not a problem of absence but of surplus: an overwhelming, unresolved influx of information across time that resists coherent transmission. The grid structure itself proposes a taxonomic mode of encountering the world — systematic, categorising, hierarchical — one that necessarily produces hierarchies not only of objects but of events, narratives, and experiences.

The title, *Consta(Nations)* folds "consternation" — bewilderment, dismay, the feeling of a world that exceeds comprehension — into "nations," framing the global expansion of the nation-state and unchecked mercantilism as sources of that condition. The violence through which states are created, borders drawn, and peoples ordered is a history that dominant modes of transmission have often obscured. Kamwathi proposes that a slower, circumspect kind of attention can yield an account of the present that does not look away from the conditions of its making.

Gallery 3



5. *Tabula Rasa*, 2026
Soft pastel, spray paint wall drawing

13. *Untitled*, 2026
Mild steel

14. *Untitled*, 2026
Mild steel

15. *Reframing II*, 2026
Etching, aquatint on paper

16. *Reframing I*, 2026
Etching, aquatint on paper

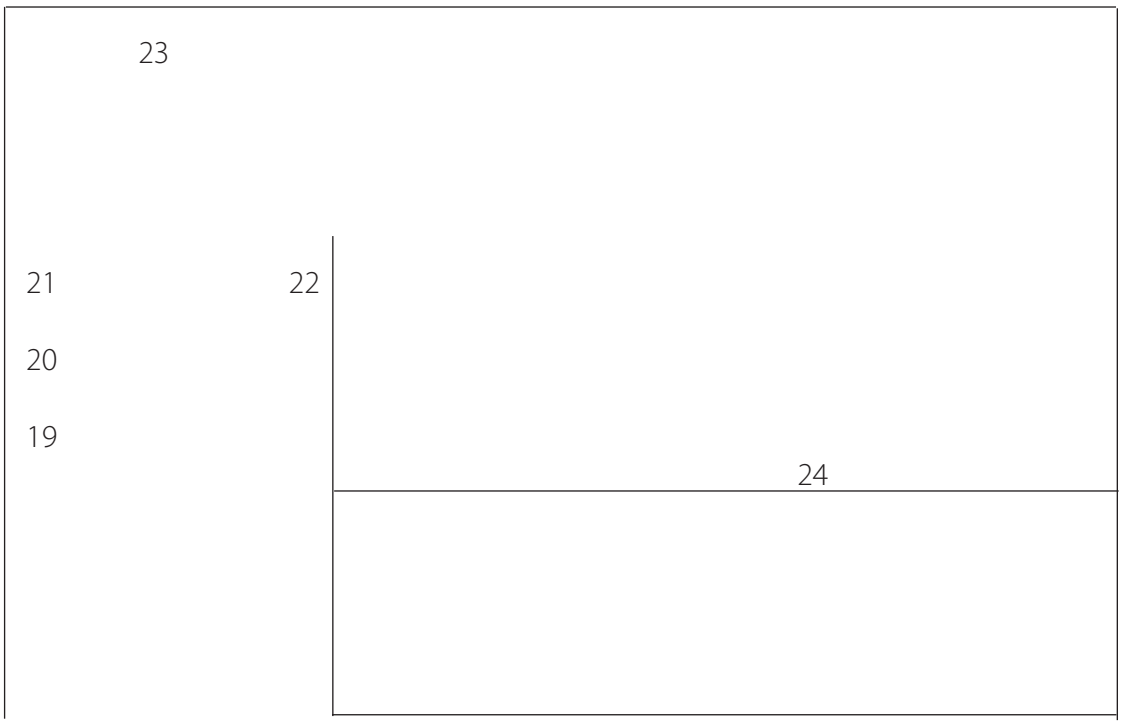
17. *Reframing III*, 2026
Etching, aquating on paper

18. *Untitled,* 2023
Graphite pencil, colour pencil, soft pastel, spray paint, silkscreen on 300gsm Canson watercolor paper

***Untitled (Etching)*, (2026)**
The background is dominated by a fragment of the toppled bronze statue of Edward Colston — the Bristol slave trader whose monument was pulled from its plinth by protesters in June 2020, dragged through the city's streets, and thrown into the harbour. Kamwathi shows the statue mid-fall, a massive form diagonal across the image, with the lower parts dissolving into the turbulent splash of its entry into the water. The monochromatic quality of the etching strips the scene of any celebratory register, returning it to something more ambiguous, more structural.

Layered over and against this is an image of three workers engaged in the erection of another monument, a pillar whose surface is covered in commodity codes. They are rendered with density and presence, their bodies straining in coordinated effort. The juxtaposition is the argument. One monument falls; another is already being raised. The logic that produces monuments to conquest, plunder, and nation-making is not dissolved by the toppling of any single one. It persists, encoded now not in the likeness of a slave trader but in the language of global commerce — barcodes, commodity indices, the administrative notation of capital.

This work insists on foregrounding the labourers themselves. These three figures, fully present, wearing work clothes and caps, their hands on the rising pillar, are not incidental. They are the image's true centre. The people who build monuments are rarely the people who commission them, and rarely the people whose histories those monuments narrate. By placing their labour at the heart of a scene about historical reckoning, Kamwathi proposes that any honest account of how power is memorialised must include those upon whose bodies and work that memorialisation depends. At upper right, a lone, slight figure looks on — distant, detached, observing. The asymmetry between that posture of watching and the exertion below it says much about how the costs of history are distributed.



19. Joel Oswaggo
Migingo, 1993
Watercolour and ink on paper

20. Rashid Diab
Historical Animal III, 1987
Etching and monoprint on paper

21. Boniface Maina
Restricted Areas III - Series (Old Realities), 2020
Acrylics on paper

22. Anthony Ng'ang'a
Natural Mystic I, 2023
Technical pen on paper

23. Anthony Ng'ang'a
Natural Mystic IV, 2023
Technical pen on paper

24. Charles Mukasa
Looting at Bombo, 1979
Oil on board

Peterson Kamwathi
B. 1980.
Lives and works between Nairobi and Limuru, Kenya.

Peterson Kamwathi's drawing-based practice examines how social and political histories are inscribed in collective behaviour and everyday life. Working across media, he treats drawing as the foundation of every form his work takes — a discipline of sustained looking through which images, objects, and the human figure are gathered, redrawn, and placed in new proximity. His surfaces are built through the layering of dry media in combination with printmaking techniques, moving beyond fixed references to foreground the associative possibilities of source materials.

Early in his practice, Kamwathi attended closely to the ceremonies that emerge whenever people congregate — in public spaces, places of worship, and the margins of everyday life — reading the postures and formations of collective life. At the centre of this inquiry is the relationship between the individual and the group: how arrangements of people carry the weight of shared social and political history without announcing it. A crowd assembles, a figure defers, a space is claimed or avoided — in these unremarkable moments, Kamwathi finds evidence of the relationships to place, to power, and to one another that organised social life quietly reproduces.

Kamwathi expanded this inquiry outward, taking the instabilities in recording and transmission of histories as both subject and method. He places human figures — solitary and grouped, their bodies caught between movement and rest — in new proximity with objects and encounters of charged historical significance: maps, cash crops, archival images of colonial violence, alongside ostensibly innocuous counterparts — high-visibility safety barriers, balloons, barcodes. All carry unstable, contingent meanings.

Kamwathi attends to the selective narration of social and political histories — what is partially retained, what is unevenly transmitted — layering drawing with silkscreening, stencilling, and various wet and dry media to produce compositions that linger on seemingly banal objects and encounters and bring into relief the charged histories they carry. The resulting images press on the gaps between what is officially recorded and what is lived, between what is visibly marked and what quietly persists — opening dominant narratives to scrutiny.

Kamwathi represented Kenya at the 57th Venice Biennale in 2017. Exhibitions include Origins Centre, University of Witwatersrand (Johannesburg, South Africa), Kochi-Muziris Biennale (Kochi, 2025), Young Congo Biennale (Kinshasa, 2019), OSTRALE'16 (Dresden), and the 8th Ake Arts and Book Festival (Lagos, 2020). His work is held in the collections of the British Museum, Bates College Museum of Art, Safaricom, AKKA Collection, the East African Visual Arts Trust, the World Bank, Imago Mundi Collection, and the Nairobi Contemporary Art Institute (NCAI).

Notes

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Kelvis Wanjia
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Ammar Suleiman
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Almond Creations Services
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NCAI is generously supported by White Cube and David Zwirner gallery